It is interesting to compare the tone and substance of this interview with the one that Putin gave to the Chinese media before his visit to China in July 2000, in which, while acknowledging the importance of the bilateral relationship, he did not frame it in the same geopolitical context as Russia's relationship with India.[4]

Strategic partnership

In a speech to the Indian Parliament in October 2000, President Putin declared that Indian and Russian geopolitical interests coincided and, therefore, the India relationship was "one of the top priorities of Russian foreign policy." From India's perspective, four major points made in his speech highlighted the strategic content of the partnership: 1) no matter how Russia's relations with other countries developed, "be it Asian or other countries," they would never be alternatives to relations with India or prejudice them; 2) Russia fully supported India's stand on international terrorism (mentioning Kashmir, Afghanistan, and Russia's north Caucasus in this context); 3) The "Kashmir issue" should be resolved bilaterally between India and Pakistan, without foreign interference; and 4) India and Russia could work together on nuclear issues without contradicting regional and international security interests (thus publicly signalling willingness for civil nuclear cooperation, even as India was under international sanctions because of its nuclear tests of 1998).[5]

On a broader canvas, India and Russia agreed on commitment to sovereignty, territorial integrity, and non-interference in international affairs, as well as opposition to external humanitarian interventions and regime change. An important area of India–Russia cooperation was India–